Methods Section Template for Survey Research Papers

Fillable PDF. Click a blue box to type; tick the small squares. Save with **File › Save** and attach the saved PDF to your assignment. Works best in the free Adobe Acrobat Reader; macOS Preview and web browsers also work. If an answer does not fit its box, continue it on an extra page. Source: `Step_12_Writing_Survey_Research_Paper/methods_section_template.md` (rebuild with `tools/make_fillable_pdfs.py`).

This is a fill-in-the-blank ("mad-libs") template for writing a rigorous methods section in a survey research paper. Replace all `[BRACKETED]` placeholders with your study-specific information. Delete any sections that do not apply to your design.

Participants and Recruitment

We recruited `[N target]` participants through `[platform or method: e.g., Prolific Academic, in-person intercept at X location, partner organization mailing list]` between `[start date]` and `[end date]`. Participants were eligible if they `[eligibility criteria, e.g., were residents of X country, were ≥18 years old, had visited Y area in the past 5 years]`. `[Any exclusion criteria at recruitment stage]`. The study was approved by the `[IRB/BREB name]` (Protocol No. `[XXXX]`, approved `[date]`) and pre-registered on `[OSF/AsPredicted/ClinicalTrials.gov]` (`[link]`). All participants provided informed `[electronic/written]` consent prior to participation and received `[compensation type and amount, e.g., £X.XX via Prolific, equivalent to ≥£X/hr]`.

Survey Instrument

The survey was administered in `[language(s)]` using `[platform, e.g., Qualtrics, KoBoToolbox]`. `[If translated: The instrument was translated from [source language] to [target language] following a forward–back-translation protocol (Edunov et al., 2018) and cognitively pre-tested with [N] native speakers (Willis, 2018); see Supplementary Materials S1 for the translation log.]`

The survey comprised the following sections, administered in this order:

1. `[Section 1 name and purpose, e.g., Consent and eligibility screener]`
2. `[Section 2 name and purpose, e.g., Wildlife tolerance scale (X items; Browne-Nuñez et al., 2015)]`
3. `[Section 3 name and purpose, e.g., Value orientation scale (X items; Manfredo et al., 2009)]`

4. [Section 4 name and purpose, e.g., Open-ended word association task]

5. [Section 5 name and purpose, e.g., Sociodemographic questions (placed last to minimize stereotype threat; Steele & Aronson, 1995)]

[If items were randomized: Item order within [section name] was randomized across respondents to control for order effects.] The full instrument is provided in Supplementary Materials [SX].

Sampling and Design

[Choose and complete the applicable paragraph(s).]

Probability / quota sample: We used a [stratified / quota / random] sampling design targeting a sample representative of [population] with respect to [demographic variables, e.g., age, gender, region]. Quotas were set based on [census year and source].

Non-probability / convenience sample: We used a [convenience / snowball / purposive] sampling approach. Given the [exploratory / theory-generating / interpretive] aim of this study (see Step 1), a probability sample was not feasible [or: was not required to answer the research question]. We document this limitation candidly in the Discussion.

Experimental design: [If applicable: Participants were randomly assigned to one of [N] conditions: [condition 1 description] vs. [condition 2 description]. Randomization was implemented via [Qualtrics randomizer / coin flip / block randomization]. Condition assignment was [single-blind / double-blind].]

Data Collection Quality Controls

To ensure data quality, we applied the following controls, pre-specified in our pre-registration: [list only those that apply]

- Qualtrics bot detection and reCAPTCHA (score threshold: [X])
- Duplicate IP and device fingerprint screening
- Embedded HTML link-engagement check for [external content]
- Minimum completion time threshold of [X] seconds, derived from [pilot median completion time / 3]
- [N] attention check items (e.g., "[item wording]"); participants failing [≥1 / ≥2] check(s) were excluded

Data Cleaning and Exclusions

Raw data were exported from [platform] and processed in [R version X.X / Python X.X]. Exclusions were applied in the following sequence:

Step	Criterion	N excluded	N remaining
0	Raw export		[N]
1	Non-consent / ineligibility	[N]	[N]
2	Bot / fraud flags	[N]	[N]
3	Speeders / attention failures / straightliners	[N]	[N]
4	[Any additional criterion]	[N]	[N]
Final	**Analysis sample**		[N]

[Missing data: Missing responses on [scale/outcome] were handled by [listwise deletion / multiple imputation using the mice package (van Buuren & Groothuis-Oudshoorn, 2011)]; the missing-completely-at-random assumption was [tested using / not tested; rationale].]

Measures

[Scale 1 Name]

[Construct] was measured using the [scale name] ([citation]), a [N]-item scale employing a [X]-point Likert response format ranging from 1 (*Strongly Disagree*) to [X] (*Strongly Agree*). [Describe any modifications verbatim.] In our sample, the scale showed [good / acceptable] internal consistency (Cronbach's α = [X], 95% CI [X–X]; McDonald's ω = [X]).

[Scale 2 Name]

[Repeat as above.]

[Open-ended / qualitative item]

Participants responded to the following open-ended prompt: "[exact wording]". Responses were coded [inductively / deductively / using a hybrid approach] by [N] coders [independently / with consensus discussion]. The final codebook (Supplementary Materials S[X]) contains [N] parent codes and [N] child codes. Inter-rater reliability was assessed on a [X]% subset using [Cohen's κ / Krippendorff's α] ([statistic] = [value]; [Lombard et al., 2002]), indicating [excellent / good / fair] agreement. Disagreements were resolved [by discussion / by a third coder].

Statistical Analysis

All analyses were conducted in [R version X.X (R Core Team, YEAR) / Python X.X] using the following packages: [list packages and versions]. The analysis plan was pre-registered at [link]; deviations from the pre-registered plan are noted in the Results.

[Describe each analysis in 1–2 sentences, e.g.:]

Scale reliability was assessed using Cronbach's α and McDonald's ω via the psych package (Revelle, [YEAR]). Confirmatory factor analysis (CFA) was conducted in lavaan ([Rosseel, 2012]); model fit was evaluated using CFI (≥0.95), RMSEA (≤0.06), and SRMR (≤0.08). [Group comparisons / regression / SEM ...] Effect sizes are reported as [partial η^2 / Cohen's d / odds ratios / standardized β] with 95% confidence intervals throughout; *p*-values are reported as supplementary information.

References *(for methods section citations)*

• Lombard, M., Snyder-Duch, J., & Campanella Bracken, C. (2002). Content analysis in mass communication. *Human Communication Research*, 28(4), 587-604.

• Rosseel, Y. (2012). lavaan: An R package for structural equation modeling. *Journal of Statistical Software*, 48(2), 1–36.

• Steele, C. M., & Aronson, J. (1995). Stereotype threat and the intellectual test performance of African Americans. *Journal of Personality and Social Psychology*, 69(5), 797–811.

• van Buuren, S., & Groothuis-Oudshoorn, K. (2011). mice: Multivariate Imputation by Chained Equations in R. *Journal of Statistical Software*, 45(3).

• Willis, G. B. (2018). *Cognitive Interviewing: A Tool for Improving Questionnaire Design*. SAGE.